



Woman in Indian dress

Despite the variety in women's traditional dress in India, the *sari* is the most widespread garment. Each region's *sari* has its own draping style and material.



Man from West Bengal, India

The *kurta* and *dhoti* combination is a traditional men's dress worn in many parts of India, mostly for festivals. The style of draping the *dhoti* varies across regions.

VELVET A silk or synthetic fabric with a short, dense *pile*, formed by weaving an extra set of looped *warp* threads into the fabric and then cutting them level, to give a soft, lustrous surface.

MEDIEVAL ▷

VELVETEEN A fabric made to imitate velvet, with a silk *pile* on a cotton ground, or made entirely of cotton.

LATE 18TH CENTURY ▷

VENETIANS Breeches that were usually widest at the hips and sometimes padded with *bombast*, and narrowed towards the knees.

c.1570–1620: SEE P.105

VENT A vertical slit partway up the side or back seam of a coat or jacket to give ease of movement.

15TH CENTURY ▷

VEST (a) A light, short-sleeved or sleeveless pull-on undergarment for the upper body, traditionally worn by men, but now common among women; also called tank top; (b) a former name for a *waistcoat*, still used in the US.

19TH CENTURY ▷

VESTMENTS Robe or gown worn to signify rank; worn by clerics of the Christian Church and others conducting services; based on everyday clothing of the 1st century.

MEDIEVAL: SEE PP.56–7

VINTAGE CLOTHING Garments and accessories from previous eras, obtained for wearing or display, or collected as memorabilia.

LATE 20TH CENTURY ▷: SEE PP.408–9

VISCOSE Another name for *rayon*.

20TH CENTURY ▷

VOILE A sheer, lightweight fabric with a crisp surface finish, mainly made of cotton but also made of silk or synthetic fibres.

1885 ▷

VOLANT A small frill or *flounce* with wavy edges, used as trimming.

19TH CENTURY ▷



W

WAISTBAND The band encircling the waist at the top of lower-body garments such as trousers and skirts.

WAISTCOAT Formerly a waist-length undercoat worn with a *doublet* or coat; today a sleeveless garment worn with a coat or jacket on formal occasions, or as a decorative feature.

16TH CENTURY ▷: SEE PP.151, 155, 210

WAIST SEAM The seam running around the centre of a formal coat or dress, joining the body to the skirts.

WARP The long threads running vertically on a loom, parallel to the *selvedge*, creating the lengthwise grain of woven fabric; see also *Weft*.

WASPIE A woman's corset with *boning* and laces that pull in the wearer's waist, giving a curvy, "wasp-waisted" shape; made popular as part of Dior's *New Look*.

LATE 1940s ▷: SEE P.316

WATERED FABRICS A term for fabrics that have a rippled pattern like a watermark on the surface, made by applying heat, moisture, and pressure; see *Tabby*, *Moiré finish*.

WATTEAU PLEATS A revival of the 18th-century *sack back* style, named for the dresses seen in paintings by 18th-century French artist Jean-Antoine Watteau.

c.1850–EARLY 20TH CENTURY: SEE P.117

WEAVE A term for the way in which the *warp* and *weft* are interwoven in a cloth; the basic types are plain (one *weft* thread crossing over one *warp* and under the next), *twill*, and *satín*.

WEDDING DRESS The bride's dress, typically white (made popular by the wedding of Queen Victoria in Britain in 1840); styles have usually been the "best dress" for the era, or, more recently, evening or Victorian-style dresses, or

unusual styles and colours (such as pink).

19TH CENTURY ▷: SEE PP.189, 200, 320–1

WEDDING SUIT The groom's suit; today's outfit of *morning coat* with striped trousers, pale *waistcoat*, and pale top hat became popular around 1920, though the *morning coat* first appeared in the 1870s.

19TH CENTURY ▷

WEDDING VEIL The bridal veil, made popular after the British Queen Victoria wore a long lace veil for her wedding in 1840; 20th-century veils were often made of *tulle*, and various styles were adopted, but many reached to the waist or below.

19TH CENTURY ▷: SEE P.200

WEDGE-SOLED SHOES High-heeled shoes popularized by Italian designer Salvatore Ferragamo, in which the sole forms one triangular piece, often made of a lightweight material such as cork, wood, or plastic.

1930s ▷: SEE PP.305, 376

WEFT The horizontal threads that are interlaced with the *warp* as a cloth is being woven, and which create the crosswise *grain* in a fabric.

WELT (a) In shoe-making, a strip of leather or other material sewn around the border between the upper and insole, to which the sole is attached; (b) a strengthened or raised border on a garment.

WHALEBONE Flexible cartilaginous material (baleen) from the upper jaw of a whale, used for *boning* in stays, corsets, and bodices.

MEDIEVAL–20TH CENTURY

WHEEL FARTHINGALE

A wheel-shaped *farthingale* that fitted around the waist, often tilted up at the back, and extended the skirts of a dress to form a cylinder shape.

1580–1620s

